Why are you here?”

“I’ve brought the sick bay report.” On the way over, she’d worked out what she’d say.

“Where’s Herr Capek?”

“He’s completing the paperwork on the death of an Italian worker this afternoon and couldn’t get away.” She held out the gray folder, doing her best to keep her arm steady.

Taking it, he motioned with his hand that she should step inside. The warmth of the fire enveloped her, melting her resolve a little, reminding her of all he had, which she lacked. *It’s only on the surface.* She had an inner strength and she’d seen his weakness. Squaring her shoulders, she pushed the shaky moment aside and took in the room. In the center stood a large desk with papers stacked on it and a lamp with a green shade.

“Remove your wet coat and sit down,” he commanded, pressing a brass bell on the table. “I’ll call for tea.”

She hung the musky, wet wool coat on a wooden stand near the door before settling into the chair across from his desk. An older woman opened a side door. He gave her curt instructions to bring two teas. Rose felt the burn of the woman’s gaze before she retreated.

“What is your connection to Herr Capek?”

“My sister types his medical reports. She asked me to come tonight to deliver them.”

“I see. Have you liked my gifts?” He smiled.

“You’re very generous.”

“How long has it been since we met in the church?”

“Four months, about. You came to say a prayer for Felix.”

He turned to the window. The rain fell hard outside, knocking against the glass. “You were kind to sit with me that night.”

Hope stole through Rose that she might reestablish the personal connection they’d had in the church. “We were both mourning family.”

“At the time . . . I had no idea the scale of the loss.” He rubbed his hands together. “It’s only recently come to light.”

She wasn’t sure what he meant. A side door opened, and the woman entered carrying a tray with tea to the table. “Anything else, Herr Reinhardt?”

“No, that will be all. You’re dismissed.”